

UCF - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-line Big 12 team with a credible defensive floor and a higher offensive ceiling than 2025, but too much OL/front/newcomer uncertainty for an above-average Power 4 projection.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes/points) · SP+ No. 63
Returning production	61% (No. 30) overall · Off. 61% (No. 39) · Def. 61% (No. 30)
Primer power rating	+1.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.0 wins · likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Slightly better
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: UCF should lean on QB Alonza Barnett III's run-pass stress, a spread-option structural projection and a deep RB rotation while trying to protect a reworked offensive line.

Bottom line: UCF has enough QB certainty, returning production and defensive competence to reach a bowl, but the Knights remain a volatile mid-tier Big 12 projection until the rebuilt OL and injury-flagged front prove stable.

Beats expectations if: Barnett turns his rushing stress into efficient passing-down offense, the transfer-heavy OL settles around OT Preston Cushman, and the defensive front gets healthy enough for LB Lewis Carter/CB Jayden Bellamy and the back seven to play from favorable down-and-distance situations.

Disappoints if: The rebuilt line recreates 2025's poor third-down/pass-efficiency profile, the front cannot replace EDGE Malachi Lawrence's disruption, and the new specialist operation costs field position or points in close Big 12 games.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** QB Alonza Barnett III is explicitly UCF's QB1; his 2025 James Madison profile included 589 rushing yards and 15 rushing touchdowns.
- Returning production:** Returning production is exactly 61% on offense and defense (61% overall), but the projected first units still rely heavily on transfers and new combinations.
- 2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense's biggest warning signs were pass efficiency No.107 and third down No.117; offensive improvement is the fastest path from 5-7 to a bowl.
- Secondary:** LB Lewis Carter (92 tackles) and CB Jayden Bellamy are stable defensive anchors, but first-round EDGE Malachi Lawrence is gone and several front players had camp health flags.
- ? Play-caller:** One late eligibility case remains outside the active 2026 projection, and the exact primary offensive play-caller remains unresolved.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	5-7 (2-7 Big 12)	● Poor
Scoring	24.3 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	378.8 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	158.0 YPG · 4.9 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	6.57 YPA · 12 TD / 12 INT	● Poor
Third downs	34.1%	● Poor
Scoring defense	23.6 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	335.8 YPG allowed	● Good / above average
Rush defense	150.7 YPG · 3.9 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	185.1 YPG · 6.63 YPA · 13 TD allowed	● Good / above average

UCF was not uniformly poor in 2025. The offense was the clear drag: scoring No.90, pass efficiency No.107 and third down No.117, with play-level offense also below average (EPA No.97, success rate No.98, adjusted offense No.118).

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-5.56 · No. 118	● Poor
Off. EPA/play	-0.073 · No. 97	● Below average
Off. success rate	40.4% · No. 98	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	11.4% · No. 92	● Below average
Havoc allowed	16.4% · No. 93	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.05 · No. 66	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.008 · No. 59	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	42.0% · No. 74	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.8% · No. 62	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	15.8% · No. 66	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: UCF's 2025 defense was more credible than the 5-7 record suggests-No.37 in total defense and roughly average by opponent-adjusted/play-level metrics-while the offense was consistently below average by EPA, success rate, explosiveness and especially third down/pass efficiency.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Scott Frost - returning same role	● ↔ Year-two continuity matters after the 2025 reset, but no primary offensive caller is inferred from Frost's title or historical context.
OC	Steve Cooper - returning same role	● ↔ Continuity supports system stability, while exact game-day play-calling responsibility remains unresolved.
DC/Safeties	Alex Grinch - returning same role	● ↔ The defense returns a coordinator and several back-seven anchors; the exact primary defensive caller remains unresolved.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Alonza Barnett III	James Madison	● ↑ Settled QB1 with meaningful dual-threat production; raises the offense's functional ceiling without proving high-end passing efficiency.
◆ RB Duke Watson	Louisville	● ↔ Major rotation piece with Doak Walker recognition; role value is real but opening workload had an availability caveat.
◆ WR Josh Derry	Monmouth	● ↔ Projected first-unit X receiver, but Power 4 translation risk limits the upgrade claim.
◆ OL Henry Tabansi	Buffalo	● ↔ Expected first-unit left tackle in a rebuilt line; material because of role need rather than proven upgrade certainty.
◆ OL Brady Wayburn	UConn	● ↔ Likely first-unit right guard; adds needed starting experience amid veteran departures.

Out	To	Loss
WR DJ Black	South Carolina	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 role leaves a receiver room already leaning on new projected starters.
IOL Carter Miller	South Carolina	● ↓ Adds to major interior-line turnover.
OL Cameron Kinnie	eligibility/graduation	● ↓ Veteran starting/contributing OL loss.
OL Jabari Brooks	eligibility/graduation	● ↓ Another veteran OL departure that increases reliance on new combinations.
QB Tayven Jackson	North Texas	● ↔ Ten-start 2025 quarterback departs, but Barnett is the supported current QB1 rather than an unresolved replacement.

Offensive net: Slightly better skill/QB ceiling but materially less OL continuity

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ EDGE Ken Talley	Arkansas	● ↔ Projected right-edge rotation help after major professional departures.
◆ EDGE Bruno Dall	Akron	● ↔ Material rotation addition, but hamstring availability lowers certainty.
◆ DT Thomas Collins	Oregon State	● ↔ Expected interior rotation depth rather than a proven EDGE Malachi Lawrence-level replacement.
◆ LB Jahleel Culbreath	Old Dominion	● ↑ Major LB rotation player with Butkus recognition; strengthens an already stable second level.

Out	To	Loss
EDGE Malachi Lawrence	NFL (Dallas), Round 1, No. 23	● ↓ First-round edge loss is the largest single defensive composition hit.
EDGE Nyjalik Kelly	NFL (Green Bay Packers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Adds another professional departure to a front already replacing EDGE Malachi Lawrence.
LB Keli Lawson	NFL (Minnesota Vikings), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful second-level loss partly buffered by LB Lewis Carter/Kozlowski/LB Jahleel Culbreath.

Defensive net: Down modestly, with the back seven steadier than the front

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Spread-option structural projection with a quarterback-run element and multiple RBs; QB Alonza Barnett III's legs should be a central stressor.	QB run threat, RB multiplicity and returning TE Dylan Wade.	Passing-down efficiency behind a rebuilt line; 2025 pass efficiency/third down were major weaknesses.
Defense	Projected 4-2-5 with continuity at linebacker and corner but a less settled front.	LB Lewis Carter/LB Cole Kozlowski at linebacker, CB Jayden Bellamy at corner and a 2025 defense that limited total yardage reasonably well.	Replacing first-round EDGE Malachi Lawrence while managing several front injuries/limitations.
Special teams	New-transfer operation at punter, kicker and long snapper.	Defined projected first-unit roles by late August.	Very little continuity and a SP+ special-teams rank of No.83.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↑	Medium	QB Alonza Barnett III is explicitly QB1 and adds major rushing value, while UCF-specific passing efficiency remains a projection.
RB	● B–	● ↔	Medium	RB Landen Chambers/RB Duke Watson and RB Swint give UCF multiple credible options.
WR	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	The projected first unit is transfer/new-role heavy after WR DJ Black's departure.
TE	● B–	● ↔	Medium	TE Dylan Wade returns as projected TE1 with Mackey recognition and transfer depth behind him.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	OT Preston Cushman is the anchor, but four veteran departures and unsettled center/guard roles create the clearest offensive risk.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↓	Low	First-round EDGE Malachi Lawrence is gone and several front players carry availability questions.
LB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Lewis Carter's 92-tackle return leads the defense's steadiest group with LB Cole Kozlowski and added depth.
Secondary	● B–	● ↔	Medium	CB Jayden Bellamy is a proven returning anchor for a pass defense that was above average in 2025.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	SP+ ranks the unit No. 83 and the projected P/K/LS roles are all new transfers.
Coaching	● B	● ↔	Medium	HC Scott Frost/OC Steve Cooper/DC Alex Grinch return in the same roles, though game-day caller attribution remains unresolved.
Overall	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	SP+ No.63 and a 6-win baseline fit a functional but volatile Power 4 team whose QB/line/front outcomes can move it materially.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Alonza Barnett III (TR: James Madison)	QB	● Above-average Power 4 starter projection / dual-threat fulcrum	Maxwell Award	Explicit QB1; his 2025 JMU profile included 589 rushing yards and 15 rushing TD.
Lewis Carter	LB	● High-end conference starter	Bednarik Award	Returns after 92 tackles as the defense's clearest proven leader.
Preston Cushman	OT	● Solid Power 4 starter / continuity anchor	-	12 starts and 753 snaps in 2025; his stability is critical in a rebuilt OL.
Jayden Bellamy	CB	● Solid Power 4 starter	-	Returning secondary leader and projected first-unit right corner.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Dylan Wade	TE	● Solid Power 4 starter	John Mackey Award	Projected TE1 and one of the offense's few clear returning role anchors.
◆ Duke Watson (TR: Louisville)	RB	● High-upside rotation back	Doak Walker Award	Could raise the run game's explosive ceiling if fully available; projected behind Landen Chambers in current ordering.
◆ Jahleel Culbreath (TR: Old Dominion)	LB	● Impact rotation / starter-upside linebacker	Butkus Award	Adds recognized talent behind a stable starting LB pair.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Moderate overall, but the middle of the schedule stacks four opponents rated above UCF before a more manageable November.
Difficulty	● 5/10 · SP+ SOS No. 65
Hardest stretch	TCU → at Houston → at Oklahoma State → BYU, with the bye before BYU
Swing games	Baylor, at Kansas, Arizona State, Iowa State, at Colorado, at Pittsburgh
Advantage	A home FCS opener and home Georgia State precede much of the Big 12 grind; five of the final six are against opponents with SP+ ratings below +5.0.
Expected	6.0 wins · likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	A 5-7 record and zero AP votes can make UCF look weaker than its defensive baseline, but a recognizable Scott Frost/Barnett offense may also attract optimism before the OL proves itself.
Back them when	Barnett's rushing threat creates favorable numbers against defenses that struggle with quarterback run stress, especially when the price treats UCF as a bottom-tier rather than mid-tier Power 4 team.
Fade/pass when	The Knights face a strong front or are asked to win through obvious passing downs before the center/guard combination and edge/interior health stabilize.
Key monitor	OL center/guard alignment, Barnett passing-down efficiency, RB Duke Watson availability/role, defensive-front health, offensive play-caller attribution if later established
Week 1 baseline	vs. Bethune-Cookman: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: UCF -42.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

UCF's bowl case starts with QB Alonza Barnett III, whose rushing value gives the offense a defined identity, plus a functional defensive spine led by LB Lewis Carter and CB Jayden Bellamy. The second-year staff also has role continuity even though exact game-day play-calling attribution is unresolved.

The volatile pieces are the OL, defensive front and specialists: four veteran OL contributors are gone, first-round EDGE Malachi Lawrence must be replaced, and the P/K/LS operation is new. That makes **SP+ No. 63 and roughly six wins** a sensible center, with upside if Barnett's passing-down efficiency and the rebuilt line improve quickly.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

© 2026 DRWhittier. Original analysis, commentary, selection, and arrangement.

Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [transfer portal](#) · [media day](#) · [injury tracker](#) · [eligibility update](#) · [NFL departure](#) · [coaching staff](#) · [fall camp](#)

Last updated: August 25, 2026